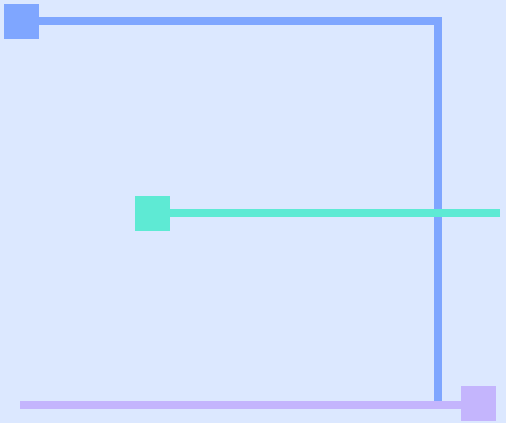
> CYBER SECURITY INTERNSHIP

Phishing Awareness: How to Stay Safe Online



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What is Phishing?

Phishing is when an attacker sends a fake message that looks like it comes from a trusted source. The goal is to trick you into giving away passwords, OTP codes or card details, or into installing malware.

It works because it targets people, not computers. It plays on trust, fear and hurry.

Email phishing

Fake emails that ask you to click a link or open a file.

Smishing

Fake SMS or WhatsApp messages with a link or a prize.

Vishing

Phone calls from someone pretending to be a bank or official.

Fake websites

Copies of login pages that steal what you type.

Why It Matters in Pakistan

150,542

complaints received by NCCIA in 2025

81,996

of them involved cyber-enabled financial crime

2,974

WhatsApp account hacking cases

These are all cybercrime complaints, not only phishing. Source: Minister of State for Interior in the National Assembly (January 2026), as reported by The News and Profit.

Social Engineering Tactics

Urgency	"Act within 24 hours or your account will be closed."
Fear	"Your account was hacked" or "legal action will be taken."
Greed	"You won a prize, scholarship or cash reward."
Authority	The message pretends to be from a bank, teacher or boss.
Curiosity	An unexpected invoice or photo attachment: what is it?

How to Spot a Phishing Email

EXAMPLE (FICTIONAL)

From: support@abc-bank-secure.example
Subject: URGENT: Account will be blocked

Dear Customer,
We noticed unusual activity. Verify your account within 24 hours or it will be suspended.

http://abc-bank-verify.example/login

- Sender address does not match the real company
- Generic greeting such as "Dear Customer"
- Urgent or threatening language
- Spelling or grammar mistakes
- Link text differs from the real address (hover to check)
- Asks for password, OTP or card details

How to Spot a Fake Website

- Read the domain name carefully (look for swapped or extra letters)
- Type the address yourself or use a saved bookmark
- Be careful with login pages opened from messages
- Watch for odd design, pop-ups and requests for extra personal data
- When unsure, open the official website or app directly

Remember

A padlock (HTTPS) only means the connection is encrypted. It does not prove that the website is genuine.

Real-World Scenarios

Fake prize SMS

"You won Rs. 50,000! Click to claim."
Red flag: you never entered a contest.

Fake job or internship offer

A "company" asks for a fee or ID card photos.
Red flag: real employers do not charge to hire you.

Fake parcel message

"Your parcel is on hold. Pay a small fee."
Red flag: you ordered nothing, or the link looks odd.

Fake account alert

"Your account will be blocked. Verify now."
Red flag: urgency and a link instead of the official app.

Other Attacks to Know

Spear phishing

A targeted message that uses your name, class or job details to look real. It is harder to spot because it seems personal.

QR code phishing

A QR code that opens a fake website. Do not scan QR codes from unknown sources, and check the address before you log in.

Malicious attachments

Files such as fake invoices or documents that can install malware when you open them. Do not open files you did not expect.

Stay Safe and What to Do

Stay safe

- Do not click unknown links or attachments
- Never share passwords or OTP codes
- Turn on 2FA (passkeys or an authenticator app are stronger than SMS codes)
- Keep your phone and apps updated
- Verify using the official website or number
- Report suspicious messages

If you clicked

1. Do not enter any details.
2. Change that account's password from a safe device, and any account using the same password.
3. Turn on 2FA.
4. Contact your bank if money or cards are involved.
5. Report the scam: NCCIA helpline 1799 or nccia.gov.pk, and tell your teacher or IT team.

Quick Quiz: True or False?

1. A padlock (HTTPS) means a website is always safe.
2. Real banks do not ask for your password or OTP over a call or SMS.
3. If an email says "act in 24 hours", you should click quickly to be safe.
4. Hovering over a link shows where it really goes.
5. Two-factor authentication can reduce the damage if your password is stolen.

Think about each answer before the next slide.

Quiz Answers

1. False: HTTPS only encrypts the connection. Phishing sites can use it too.
2. True: real banks do not ask for your password or OTP by call or SMS.
3. False: urgency is a warning sign. Stop and verify first.
4. True: hovering shows the real address behind the link text.
5. True: 2FA can reduce the damage if your password is stolen.

Key Takeaways

- Phishing tricks people, not computers.
- Check the sender, the link and the request before you act.
- Never share passwords or OTP codes.
- Use 2FA and report suspicious messages.

When in doubt: stop, check and ask.

Sources

- CISA, NSA, FBI and MS-ISAC: Phishing Guidance: Stopping the Attack Cycle at Phase One (October 2023), cisa.gov
- CISA: Avoiding Social Engineering and Phishing Attacks, cisa.gov
- NCCIA complaint figures for 2025: Minister of State for Interior in the National Assembly, as reported by The News and Profit (January 2026)
- NCCIA website: nccia.gov.pk, and its cyber helpline 1799 (reported by ProPakistani and in the National Assembly)

All example messages in this presentation are fictional.